against his regent, and would soon be sending angry messages to Bairam detailing them; but he never, not once, accuses him of contemplating treason.

Whatever happened that night, the hunting party did not return to Delhi the next day; instead, it went further south towards Agra, where Bairam was camped. It might be the case that Akbar wanted to confront his Khan Baba face to face and demand answers to Maham Mama's allegations. And it is certainly the case that Maham made every effort to prevent such a meeting.

'The mystery of the world is like the course of the ass,' writes Badauni, quoting an Arab proverb, 'when it goes forward it does go forward, when it goes back it does go back.' Bairam's fortune, too, had changed its direction. Thus, when Akbar and his entourage reached Agra's outskirts, Maham tried to enlist another relative into her plot. He refused, and sent word to Bairam instead, telling him what was going on. The regent wouldn't believe it.

How often, in the months to come, he must have kicked himself for ignoring so clear a warning. But the ass had begun its backward course. Not only was Bairam blind to signs of danger, he did not hurry to meet Akbar either – expecting, it seems, the padishah to come to him. Maham, meanwhile, convinced Akbar to leave without meeting his proud regent.

According to Abul Fazl, Akbar used a clever 'motive' for returning to Delhi – that his mother, Hamida, was unwell in that city. It's a revealing story: that Akbar should need excuses to leave without paying court to his own regent. Badauni tells a messier tale. According to him, it was Maham who told Akbar that Hamida was ill and insisted he return to Delhi. Did Maham feel that if Akbar met Bairam the regent would convince him of his loyalty, leaving Maham and her associates exposed to the regent's revenge? She knew full well how Bairam treated his enemies.

It had been nine days since Akbar had left on his purported 'hunt'. For nine days, Maham had argued against his regent, perhaps even painting frightening pictures of Bairam's plot to overthrow him. Now, she played her trump card.

Maham Anaka came to Akbar overwrought. When Bairam found out that Akbar had left for Delhi at Maham's say-so, he would 'avenge himself' on her, she cried. Maham, poor woman, had 'no power to resist' the regent; all she could hope for was Akbar's permission to leave for Mecca.[89] She would